

LESSONS FROM HISTORY · LESSON 1

تاریخ سے سبق

How do we even know what really happened?

ہمیں کیسے پتا کہ اصل میں ہوا کیا تھا؟

The whole muqaddima, in one sitting

An old document shows up in court

The Jews of Baghdad bring an old, worn-out paper to the authorities.

The claim: after Khaybar, the Prophet ﷺ freed them from jizya — for good.

The signatures on it: ‘Alī · Sa‘d ibn Mu‘ādh · Mu‘āwiyah

کاغذ واقعی پرانا لگتا ہے۔ سب ماننے کو تیار ہیں...

One look was enough

Imam al-Khatib: “This is a fake.”

PROBLEM 1

Mu‘āwiyah became Muslim AFTER Khaybar.

So how did he sign a Khaybar deal?

PROBLEM 2

Sa‘d ibn Mu‘ādh had died years before, at Khandaq.

A dead man, signing?

The dates gave the whole thing away.

History isn't just the nice stories we like.

There's a way to check it. So — who has that 'way'?

Quick — what even counts as 'history'?

It comes down to time-order

In a poem

شاعری

told to move you, to give a lesson

In a hadith book

حدیث

sorted by chains and rulings

In a tārikh

تاریخ

sorted by TIME — first things first

Same event, three books. Only the tārikh puts it in time-order.

یہی ترتیبِ زمانی تاریخ کو تاریخ بناتی ہے۔

Two ways to know the past

THE MODERN / WESTERN WAY

- Mostly digging, guessing, joining the dots.
- No chain of who-said-what.
- No fixed rule to accept or drop a report.
- Yet they still trust the Old Testament and Ramayana as top sources.

THE ISLAMIC WAY

- Every report carries a chain — back to the eyewitness.
- We keep a file on every narrator ('ilm asmā' al-rijāl).
- So we can actually grade a report.
- We'll drop even Wāqidī, a judge of Baghdad, if the rule says so.

So “no historical basis” often just means: “it doesn't fit our guess.”

لَمَّا اسْتَعْمَلَ الرُّوَاةُ الْكَذِبَ اسْتَعْمَلْنَاهُمْ التَّارِيخَ

“When people started forging reports, we caught them with dates.”

— Sufyān al-Thawrī

اگر تاریخیں اتنی اہم ہیں... تو ہم خود وقت میں کہاں کھڑے ہیں؟

First, just two points

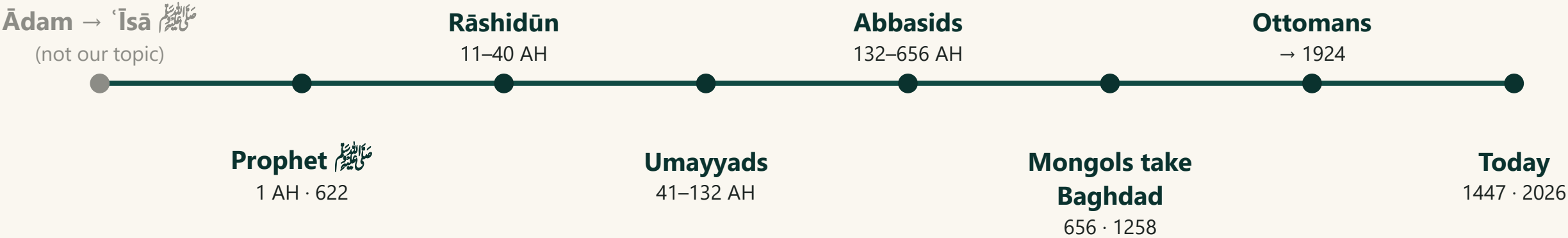
Ādam → 'Isā ﷺ
prophets
(not our topic)

The Prophet ﷺ

Hijra = 1 AH
622 CE

سب کچھ یہیں سے شروع — ہجرت سے — اور آگے چلتا ہے۔

And here's the whole journey — our 10 weeks



A letter dated just “Sha‘bān”

A letter reaches ‘Umar[ؓ], dated only “Sha‘bān.” He asks: which year's Sha‘bān?

The state has grown huge. Papers everywhere. Nobody can tell which file is from which year.

They sit together: count from the Prophet's ﷺ birth? his passing? the Hijra?

‘Umar[ؓ] picks the HIJRA — “it's the thing that separated truth from falsehood.”

اور اسی طرح ہمارا کیلنڈر — اور اس لکیر کا صفر — بنا۔

A twist: the calendar someone had tampered with

النسئ — shifting the months

Before Islam, the mushrikūn used to shuffle the months — to keep Hajj sitting in the same trading season.

They'd slip in an extra 13th month when it suited them, so the four “sacred months” drifted off their real place.

At the Farewell Hajj the Prophet ﷺ ended it for good: “Time has come back round to how Allah made it the day He created the heavens and the earth.”

اسی لیے سیرت کی کچھ تاریخوں میں فرق ہے — یہ اُس کی ایک بڑی وجہ ہے۔

First, a bit of geography



POINT AT:

- Makkah & Madina
- Rome (Byzantium): Sham, Egypt
- Persia (Sasanians): Iraq, Iran
- The road the conquests take:
 - Hijaz → Sham → Iraq → Egypt → Persia

Map: Kings & Generals — "Early Muslim Expansion" (video frame)

لَقَدْ كَانَ فِي قَصَصِهِمْ عِبْرَةٌ لِأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ

"In their stories is a lesson for people who think." (Yūsuf 12:111)

OUR RULES FOR THIS COURSE

- ہر بات کا کوئی ماخذ ہو۔ ”میں نے سنا ہوتا“ نہیں چلے گا — ہم سند کی پیروی کریں گے۔
- صحابہؓ کے بارے میں حُسنِ ظن۔ بلا ضرورت، یا عقیدے کو نقصان پہنچانے والے انداز میں اُن کے اختلافات (مشاہرات) پڑھنا ہماری فقہ میں مکروہ ہے۔
- جب ہم اُن واقعات تک پہنچیں گے (سبق ۵ اور ۷)، پورے ادب کے ساتھ۔

One thing to be clear about from day one

This is the history of the Muslims

“Tārīkh al-Islām” really means Tārīkh al-Muslimīn — the history of the MUSLIMS, not of the religion itself.

The religion is perfect. The Muslims are people — there are highs and lows, just caliphs and also unjust kings, closeness to the dīn and sometimes distance from it.

تو جب کوئی برا واقعہ آئے — اُسے اسلام کے کھاتے میں مت ڈالو۔ یہ انسانوں کی کہانی ہے، دین کی نہیں۔

So who saved all this?

یہ سب بچایا کس نے؟
چودہ سو سال بعد بھی ہمیں پتا ہے — کیسے؟

It all stands on two things — both from hadith

Two pillars

Seerah-nigārī

سیرت و معانی

Writing the Prophet's ﷺ life in proper time-order. This is the root of all our history-writing.

Fann al-Rijāl

علم أسماء الرجال

A full file on every narrator. Built to protect hadith and history — so any liar gets caught.

How any science gets built — in four steps

Building the house

1 · TĀSĪS

تأسيس

lay the foundation

2 · TADWĪN

تدوين

raise the walls (gather)

3 · TANQĪH

تنقيح

plaster & clean (sift)

4 · TAKMĪL

تكميل

paint & furnish (perfect)

History-WRITING began before Islam (Greeks, Romans...). Muslims turned it into a real science — gathered it (2nd–4th c. AH), sifted it (7th), perfected it (8th, Ibn Khaldūn).

Meet the giants

Ibn Ishāq (d.151) → Ibn Hishām (d.213): the seerah we still read most — Sīrat Ibn Hishām.

Wāqidī (d.207) & his student Ibn Sa‘d (d.230): one vivid but loose, one careful. Ibn Sa‘d's Ṭabaqāt is a treasury of the Companions.

Balādhurī (d.279): the conquests, city by city — Futūḥ al-Buldān.

⚠ **Ya‘qūbī & Mas‘ūdī (d.346):** were Shī‘a — parts tilt against the Companions. We read them aware.

Five books. Almost everything else comes from these.

The five big ones

Tārīkh al-Ṭabarī

d.310

The big well: every report with its chain.

Al-Kāmil

Ibn al-Athīr d.630

Year by year, cleaned up.

Tārīkh al-Islām

Dhahabī d.748

The most careful sieve.

Al-Bidāya

Ibn Kathīr d.774

Chains + reason; easiest read.

Ibn Khaldūn

d.808

Its Muqaddima started social science.



Fun fact — two men, same name:

There were TWO Ṭabarīs with the exact same name. Ours (grandson of Yazīd) is the Sunnī imam; the other (from Rustam) was Shīʿa. The mix-up has fooled people into calling our Ṭabarī a Shīʿa. He wasn't.

The “wine cup” story

A story went around: Ma'mūn al-Rashīd tested Imām al-Shāfi'ī with enough wine to floor any man, and it did nothing to him.

Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Ḥajar took it apart in two lines:

- History: al-Shāfi'ī meeting Ma'mūn isn't even proven. The chain fails.
- Common sense: al-Shāfi'ī said he'd skip even cold water if it dulled his mind. A wine cup?!

Next week

The story begins — Abu Bakrؓ

خلافتِ راشدہ اور سیدنا ابوبکر صدیقؓ

We start exactly where the seerah ended, and put our first bright peg on the timeline.

گھر لے جانے والا سوال: کوئی تاریخ کی ”بات“ سنائے — تو اب آپ سب سے پہلے *کیا* پوچھیں گے؟

Sources

- Course text — Tareekh-e-Ummat, Maulana Muhammad Ismail Rehan, Vol. 1 (the muqaddima).
- The forged document — al-Muntaẓam, Ibn al-Jawzī (muqaddima p.57–58).
- Method, isnād, the giants & books — muqaddima p.43–49, 69–78.
- Hijri calendar & Nasī' — al-Shamārīkh, al-Suyūṭī; Tarīkh al-Ṭabarī; al-Tawba 9:37 (muqaddima p.35–40).
- Fiqh of studying history — muqaddima p.52–53. ‘ibrah āyah — Yūsuf 12:111.
- The 'wine' story — Lisān al-Mīzān, Ibn Ḥajar (muqaddima p.57).
- Map (slide 12) — frame from Kings & Generals, “Early Muslim Expansion” (YouTube).